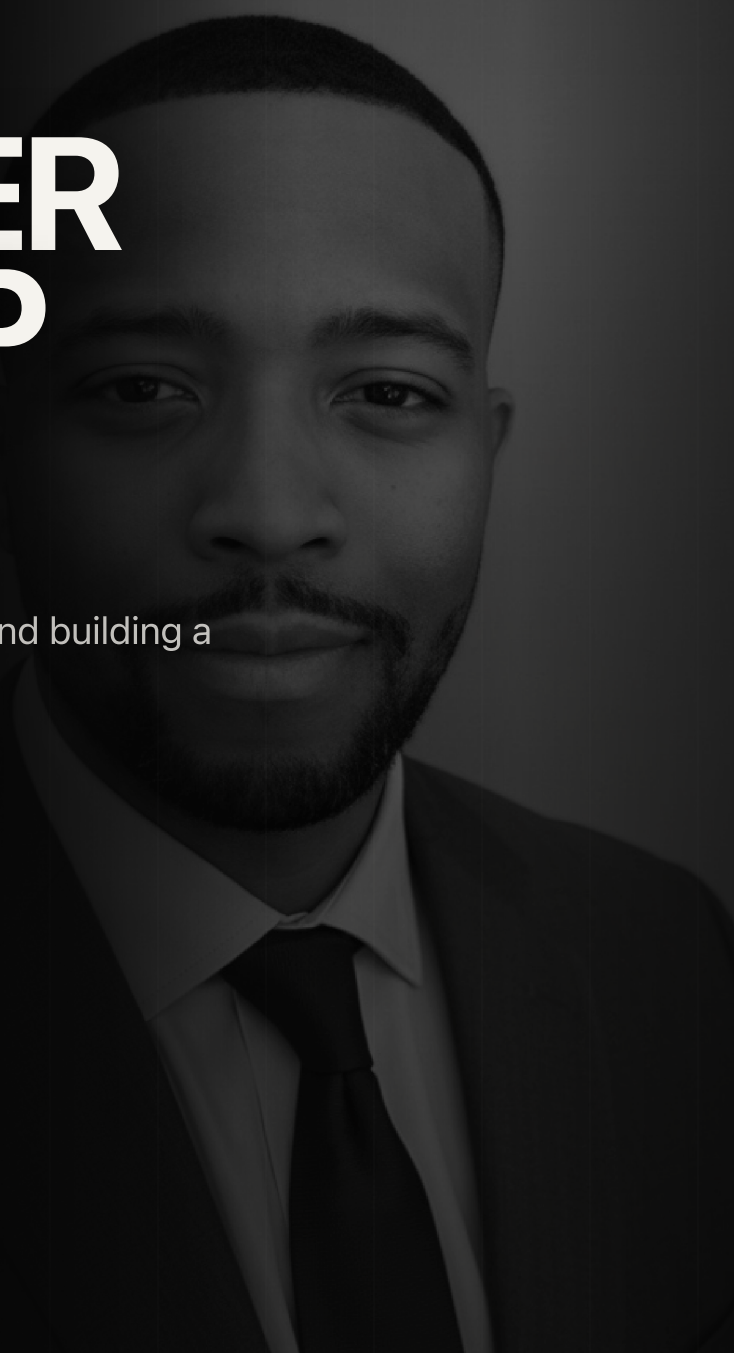


A grayscale portrait of Brandon Stevens, a man with a beard and mustache, wearing a suit and tie, looking directly at the camera. The portrait is positioned on the right side of the page, partially overlapping the title text.

PM CAREER ROADMAP GUIDE

A practical guide for breaking into project management, growing into senior roles, and building a credible PM portfolio.

THE PM CAREER LADDER

Project management is not one job. It is a ladder of operating scope.

Level	What you own	Signal you are ready for the next level
Coordinator	Meetings, notes, trackers, logistics	You keep work organized without being chased.
Project Manager	Single-project delivery	You manage scope, risk, status, and stakeholders.
Senior PM	Complex or cross-functional work	You make tradeoffs visible and influence leaders.
Program Manager	Related projects and shared outcomes	You manage dependencies across teams.
TPM	Technical delivery with product/engineering	You translate complexity into decisions.
PMO / Delivery Leader	Governance, portfolio, standards	You improve the system, not just the project.

BUILD YOUR PM SKILL STACK

You need credibility in both delivery mechanics and business judgment.

Skill	What good looks like	Practice move
Planning	Clear scope, milestones, dependencies	Build a one-page plan for a real or sample project.
Risk	Issues surface before they explode	Maintain a risk register for 30 days.
Communication	Different audiences get the right altitude	Write a weekly status update in executive format.
Stakeholders	You know influence, interest, and goals	Create a stakeholder map for a current initiative.
Tools	You pick tools based on workflow	Practice Jira, Smartsheet, or MS Project basics.
AI fluency	You use AI to accelerate drafts, summaries, and analysis	Create prompts for meeting notes and risk reviews.

CREDENTIAL NOTE

A certification can help, but it is not a substitute for delivery evidence. If you pursue PMP or another credential, pair it with a portfolio that shows how you think.

YOUR PM PORTFOLIO

A portfolio turns 'I can manage projects' into proof.

You do not need confidential employer artifacts. Create sanitized samples that demonstrate your operating style without naming companies, clients, or internal systems.

Artifact	What to include	What to avoid
Project charter	Problem, objective, scope, milestones, roles	Company names, internal financials, private stakeholders
Risk register	Risks, scoring, owners, responses	Real incident details
Status report	RAG, wins, risks, decisions needed	Sensitive metrics
Stakeholder map	Roles and influence categories	Actual names
Retrospective	What changed and why	Blame or confidential details

PORTFOLIO BUILDER

ARTIFACT 1

ARTIFACT 2

ARTIFACT 3

WHAT EACH PROVES

WHAT MUST BE ANONYMIZED

BREAK INTO PM WORK

Your first PM role may come through operations, coordination, implementation, or client delivery.

1. Translate your past work into PM language: scope, stakeholders, risks, deadlines, outcomes.
2. Target roles that value coordination and delivery: project coordinator, implementation specialist, operations analyst, client delivery associate.
3. Build two sample artifacts and link them in applications.
4. Practice explaining one project using STAR+.
5. Network with people who manage delivery, not only recruiters.

RESUME POSITIONING

Do not write 'responsible for tasks.' Write what changed because you owned the work: reduced delays, clarified ownership, improved visibility, accelerated handoffs, or protected deadlines.

GROW INTO SENIOR PM / TPM

Senior PMs are paid for judgment under ambiguity.

Junior signal	Senior signal
Tracks tasks	Manages tradeoffs
Reports status	Creates decision-ready options
Escalates problems	Escalates with recommendation
Owens one team	Coordinates across functions
Follows process	Improves process
Uses tools	Designs operating rhythm

SENIOR READINESS AUDIT

LARGEST SCOPE
MANAGED

MOST COMPLEX
STAKEHOLDER
GROUP

HARDEST TRADEOFF
MADE

PROCESS IMPROVED

EXECUTIVE
COMMUNICATION
EXAMPLE

30-DAY CAREER ACTION PLAN

Small, concrete actions beat vague career ambition.

Days	Action
1-7	Choose target role family and rewrite resume headline.
8-14	Build two sanitized PM artifacts.
15-21	Practice three STAR+ stories and update LinkedIn.
22-30	Apply to 15 targeted roles and message 10 PMs or delivery leaders.

CAREER SPRINT TRACKER

TARGET ROLE

TARGET INDUSTRIES

RESUME HEADLINE

PORTFOLIO LINK

APPLICATIONS SENT

PEOPLE CONTACTED

BRANDON STEVENS, PMP

FINAL NOTE

Project management is a craft of clarity.

The people who grow fastest are not always the loudest or most credentialed. They are the ones who make work easier to understand, decisions easier to make, and teams easier to trust.

Use this guide as your starting map. Build evidence. Keep moving.

— Brandon Stevens, PMP